

READ IT IN CONTEXT

A Christian's Honest Reply to the Hardest Questions About Jesus, the Bible, and Islam

“But sanctify the Lord God in your hearts; and always be ready to give an answer to everyone who asks you a reason concerning the hope that is in you, with humility and fear.”

1 Peter 3:15 (WEB)

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A Note on the Scriptures and on Tone

Every Bible verse in this book is quoted from the **World English Bible (WEB)**, a public-domain translation anyone may read, copy, and share. Where I refer to the Qur'an or Islamic tradition, I do so as an outsider trying to represent it fairly; I will say plainly when I am describing rather than agreeing, and I welcome correction where I have misunderstood.

This book makes a case. It does not throw a punch. The command above — to give an answer "with humility and fear" — is binding on me as I write. I will compare beliefs honestly, including where we genuinely differ, but I will not mock the Prophet of Islam, the Qur'an, or you. If you put this book down feeling insulted, I will have failed at something Scripture requires of me. If you put it down disagreeing but respected, we can keep talking — and that is the goal.

A Note to Every Reader

Christianity and Islam are the two largest families of faith on earth, and between them they shape the lives of more than half the human race. They share a great deal: belief in one Creator God, reverence for many of the same prophets, a moral seriousness about how life should be lived, and a conviction that what we believe about God is the most important thing about us.

And they differ on the single most important question a person can ask: **Who is Jesus?** Was He a great prophet and nothing more, or was He, as Christians confess, God come in the flesh to save the world? Everything else in this book orbits that question.

I have written it because the conversation between Christians and Muslims is too often conducted as a shouting match, with each side quoting its strongest verses at the other and neither side listening. There is a better way, and it is captured in three words that title this book: **read it in context**. Read the Bible the way you would want your own scripture read — whole, in context, in its own language, honestly. Do that, and many of the standard objections dissolve, while the real question comes into sharp focus.

To my Muslim reader especially: you are my honored guest in these pages. Read, weigh, and decide for yourself.

Chapter One — The Rule of Context

How to read anyone's book fairly

Imagine someone took a single sentence from the middle of one of your letters, stripped away everything before and after it, and announced that it proved you believed something you do not believe. You would object — rightly — that they had ignored the context. A text without a context is a pretext for whatever the reader already wants to say.

This is the first and most important rule of honest reading, and it applies to the Bible, the Qur'an, and every other text: **a verse means what it means in its setting** — its sentence, its paragraph, its book, its author's purpose, its original language, and its historical moment. Pull a line out of that setting and you can make it say almost anything.

Most of the sharpest Christian–Muslim disputes are, at bottom, disputes about context. Does a verse in Isaiah predict Muhammad? Does the Bible command Christians to follow every later prophet? Did Jesus claim to be God or deny it? In nearly every case, the argument that sounds devastating in isolation looks very different once you read the surrounding paragraph. So before we touch a single controversy, let us agree on the rule that should govern all of them: read it in context.

The common ground we should not skip past

It has become common in debate to rush straight to the differences. But honesty requires naming the enormous common ground first, because it is real and it matters.

- **We both confess one God.** "Hear, Israel: Yahweh is our God. Yahweh is one" (Deuteronomy 6:4). The Christian Scriptures are relentlessly monotheistic. Whatever you have heard, Christians do not worship three gods — more on that in the next chapter.
- **We both reject idolatry** as the gravest of errors. The first commandment given to Israel was, "You shall have no other gods before me" (Exodus 20:3).
- **We both honor many of the same figures** — Adam, Noah, Abraham, Moses — as real men who walked with God.
- **We both believe** God speaks, that He will judge the world, that there is a real heaven and a real hell, and that how we respond to God now has eternal weight.

That is not a small overlap. It means the conversation between us is not between a believer and an atheist, but between two communities who agree that God is real, that He is one, and that truth about Him is worth everything. The disagreement is sharp precisely because the

stakes are shared.

What honest disagreement looks like

To "read in context" cuts both ways. It means a Christian must not quote the Qur'an out of context to score points, and it means a Muslim is invited to read the Bible whole rather than through a handful of contested verses. It also means we must let each text speak in its own voice before we judge it. In what follows I will try to state the Muslim objection as a thoughtful Muslim would state it — not a straw version — and then answer it from the Scriptures in context. If I ever fail to represent your view fairly, the failure is mine, and the remedy is the same rule: read it in context.

The same words, different meanings

There is a particular trap in Christian–Muslim conversation that derails more dialogues than any other, and naming it kindly will save us much grief. It is this: we often use the *same words* while meaning *different things*. Both faiths say "God," "prophet," "Word of God," "gospel," "Messiah," even "Jesus." But the content poured into those words differs, sometimes enormously. When a Muslim says "Jesus," he means a great prophet who was not crucified and is not divine; when a Christian says "Jesus," he means God the Son, crucified and risen. Same name, very different person.

This is not, I want to stress, anyone being *deceptive* — it is simply the ordinary hazard of two rich traditions sharing a vocabulary. But if we do not slow down and *define our terms*, we will talk past each other for hours, each thinking the other has agreed or disagreed when neither has understood. Honest dialogue does the patient work of asking, "When you say that word, what exactly do you mean?" The command Scripture gives the Christian fits here perfectly:

"Give diligence to present yourself approved by God, a workman who doesn't need to be ashamed, properly handling the word of truth." — 2 Timothy 2:15 (WEB)

"Properly handling" — literally, cutting straight. To read in context is to handle words honestly: to let each text mean what it means, and to make sure that when we agree or disagree, we are actually talking about the same thing. Much of what looks like a deep clash between the faiths is, at least at first, a clash of definitions. Clear the fog of shared-but-different words, and the real questions stand out sharply — which is exactly what makes them worth facing.

Reading charitably, in both directions

There is a golden rule for handling someone else's sacred text, and it is simply the Golden Rule applied to reading: interpret the other's faith as you would want yours interpreted. None of us wants our deepest convictions represented by their weakest or strangest version, quoted out of context, or reduced to a caricature. So a Christian writing about Islam must resist the cheap victory of attacking a straw Muslim, and a Muslim weighing Christianity should resist hearing only its critics. Scripture itself rebukes the rush to refute before understanding:

"He who answers before he hears, that is folly and shame to him." — Proverbs 18:13 (WEB)

To "answer before he hears" — to fire off a rebuttal before truly grasping what the other believes — is named folly. This cuts against the grain of most religious argument online, which is built almost entirely on answering before hearing. The patient, harder, more honest way is to first state the other's view so fairly that they would say, "Yes, that is what I believe" — and only then to weigh it.

This book tries to do that with Islam, and it asks the same courtesy in return for the Christian claims it makes. Reading charitably is not the same as agreeing; it is the precondition for an honest disagreement. We can differ sharply about who Jesus is and still refuse to bear false witness about each other. Indeed, the command not to bear false witness applies to how we represent our neighbor's beliefs, not only his actions. So let the comparison that follows be a fair fight or no fight at all — each view stated at its strongest, then tested by the texts in context.

Chapter Two — One God: Tawhid and the Trinity

The objection, stated fairly

No Christian doctrine troubles a Muslim more than the Trinity. From within Islam it can look like the very thing the Qur'an most forcefully condemns: *shirk*, the association of partners with God. *Tawhid* — the absolute, indivisible oneness of God — is the heart of Islam, and to a Muslim ear the claim that God is "Father, Son, and Holy Spirit" sounds like three gods, or like making a man into God. The objection is sincere and serious: *How can you say God is one and then count to three? How can the Creator have a son?*

I want to honor that concern, because it comes from a right instinct — a jealousy for God's oneness that the Bible itself shares. So let me say clearly what Christians do **not** believe before I say what we do.

What the Trinity is not

Christians do not believe in three gods. That is tritheism, and it is a heresy the church has always rejected. We recite the same confession Israel recited: "Yahweh is one" (Deuteronomy 6:4) — the very verse Jesus called the greatest commandment (Mark 12:29).

Christians do not believe God had a wife and a child. The Qur'an rightly rejects the idea that God took a consort and physically fathered a son; so do we. When the Bible calls Jesus "the Son of God," it does not mean God married and reproduced. It means something the next chapters will unfold: that the eternal Word of God, who was always with God, came among us.

Christians do not believe a man was promoted to godhood, as pagans deified their emperors. We believe the reverse: that God humbled Himself to become man.

What the Trinity is

Here is the actual Christian confession: **there is one God, who exists eternally as Father, Son, and Holy Spirit — one Being, three persons.** Not three gods (that breaks oneness), and not one person wearing three masks (that denies the real distinctions Scripture shows). One "What" and three "Whos."

The Bible holds both truths at once. God is one (Deuteronomy 6:4; "I am God, and there is no other," Isaiah 45:22). And the Father is God, the Son is God (John 1:1), and the Spirit is God

— distinct yet one. At Jesus' baptism all three appear at once: the Son in the water, the Spirit descending, the Father's voice from heaven (Matthew 3:16-17). Jesus sends His followers to baptize "in *the name*" — singular — "of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit" (Matthew 28:19): one name, three persons.

Is this really "association"?

The Muslim worry is that calling Jesus divine *associates* a creature with God — the sin of shirk. But everything turns on whether Jesus is a creature *outside* God, or is *within* the identity of the one God. If the Son were a created being whom we then worshipped, the Muslim would be right to call it idolatry, and so would the Bible (Isaiah 42:8, "I will not give my glory to another"). The Christian claim is precisely that the Son is *not* "another" — not a second god beside the Creator, but the eternal Word of the one God, who "was God" before the world began (John 1:1).

So the dispute between us is not really "one God versus three gods." We both insist God is one. The dispute is *who the one God is*: a solitary single person, or one God eternally rich in fellowship — Father, Son, and Spirit. That is a real and deep difference. But it is not the difference Muslims often think it is. We are not counting to three. We are saying the One is fuller than we imagined. (Our companion book *Hear, O Israel* traces this all through the Hebrew Scriptures.)

The Trinity Christians actually reject — and the one we confess

Here is a striking thing that should bring our two faiths closer before it divides them. The Qur'an appears, in one place, to describe the Christian Trinity as God, Jesus, and *Mary* — and to reject worshiping Mary and Jesus as two gods alongside God (Surah 5:116). And to that, every faithful Christian says a hearty *amen*: we reject that "trinity" too. We do not believe God took a wife, that Mary is divine, or that there are three gods. If that is what the Trinity meant, it would be the very idolatry the Bible most forbids: "I am Yahweh. That is my name. I will not give my glory to another" (Isaiah 42:8).

So part of the disagreement between us may rest on a misunderstanding of what Christians actually claim. The Trinity is not God plus two others promoted to deity. It is the confession that the *one* God — the one Yahweh of the Shema — has eternally existed as Father, Son, and Holy Spirit: one Being, three persons, no division of His oneness:

"In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God... The Word became flesh, and lived among us." — John 1:1, 14 (WEB)

The Son is not a creature beside God, nor a second deity, nor Mary's elevation — He is the eternal Word who *was God* and became flesh. Mary is honored as the mother of the Lord, never worshiped. When we understand each other accurately, the dispute narrows to one real and serious question: not "do Christians believe in three gods?" (we do not), but "is Jesus the eternal Word of the one God, or only a prophet?" That is a true difference, worth all our honesty — but it is not the cartoon of three gods that sometimes stands in its place.

Why the one God is rich, not lonely

There is a question worth raising gently, because it reaches the heart of why Christians confess God as Father, Son, and Spirit rather than as a single solitary person. The Bible makes a claim about God's very nature that a solitary monotheism cannot easily make: that "God is love" (1 John 4:8) — not merely that God *is loving* toward His creatures, but that love is what God eternally *is*, in His own being.

But love requires an object. A person who is utterly alone cannot be *loving* until there is someone to love; love would be something such a god *began* to do once he created, not something he eternally *is*. The Christian confession answers this: the one God has never been a solitary monad, because the Father has eternally loved the Son in the joy of the Spirit. Jesus prays to the Father, "you loved me before the foundation of the world" (John 17:24). Before there was a universe, before there was anything to create, there was love within God — the Father, the Son, and the Spirit in eternal communion.

This is not a math problem (one cannot be three) but a window into why God is good news. It means God did not create us out of loneliness or need, but out of the overflow of a love already full. It means that at the foundation of all reality is not a distant solitary will but self-giving love, older than time. We raise this not to win an argument but to show that the Trinity, far from compromising God's greatness, magnifies it: the one God is so rich in His own being that He *is* love, and has been, eternally. That is a God worth knowing — and a claim worth weighing honestly, whatever you conclude.

Chapter Three — Has the Bible Been Corrupted?

The objection, stated fairly

A common Muslim response to any Bible verse a Christian cites is: *but your scripture has been changed*. This is the doctrine often called **tahrif** — the belief that Jews and Christians altered or corrupted their Scriptures, so that the Bible we now hold is not the pure revelation originally given to Moses and Jesus. If that were true, it would end the conversation: there would be no point examining the text, since the text could not be trusted.

It is a fair move to make *if* it is true. So let us test it — not with assertion, but with evidence, because this is a historical claim and history can be examined.

What the Qur'an itself says about previous scripture

It is worth noting, respectfully, that the charge of wholesale corruption sits uneasily with the Qur'an's own high regard for the earlier scriptures. The Qur'an repeatedly speaks of the Torah (*Tawrat*) and the Gospel (*Injil*) as guidance and light given by God, and it calls the People of the Book to *judge by* and *stand fast upon* what was revealed to them. It is difficult to command people to judge by a book that has been hopelessly corrupted. Muslim scholars have themselves long debated whether tahrif means the *text* was altered or only its *interpretation* was twisted. I raise this not to argue Islam against itself, but to show that "the Bible is corrupted" is not as simple or settled a claim as it is often presented in debate.

What the manuscripts actually show

Set the theology aside and look at the evidence. If the Bible had been corrupted at some point, we would expect to find it — an earlier, purer version that was later overwritten. The opposite is the case.

For the New Testament, we possess thousands of Greek manuscripts, plus many early translations and quotations, spread across the whole ancient world — including substantial copies that predate Islam by centuries, and fragments of the Gospels from within a century or two of the events. When scholars compare them, two things emerge. First, there are differences — "variants" — exactly the small copying mistakes you would expect from hand-copying across centuries (a slip of spelling, a repeated word). Honest Christians say so plainly. Second, and decisively, *the message is not in doubt*. No variant hides the cross, the

resurrection, the deity of Christ, or the call to repent and believe. The very abundance of manuscripts is what lets us see the variants and reconstruct the text — textual criticism works *because* the evidence is overwhelming, not because it is missing.

For the Old Testament, the Dead Sea Scrolls — copies of Hebrew Scripture from before the time of Jesus — show that the text was transmitted with remarkable care across more than a thousand years.

The fingerprint that isn't there

Here is the heart of the matter. The high view of Jesus — His deity, His death on the cross, His resurrection — is present in the *earliest* manuscripts we can reach, on every continent the church spread to, in many languages, copied by communities with no power to coordinate with one another. If that teaching had been inserted later by corruption, it would have left fingerprints: rival manuscript families, regions preserving the "original" prophet-only Jesus, church fathers protesting the change. There is no such trace. The evidence runs the other way: the Jesus who is crucified, risen, and worshipped is in the oldest layer we have.

*"The grass withers, the flower fades; but the word of our God stands forever." —
Isaiah 40:8 (WEB)*

So when a Christian quotes the Bible to you, you are within your rights to test what it says. But "it's been changed" is not a historical answer; it is a way of not having the conversation. The text we hold is, by every measure available to history, the text the first Christians wrote. The real question is not whether the Bible was corrupted, but whether what it plainly says is *true*.

What the evidence actually looks like

It is fair to ask for specifics rather than assurances, so here are some. For the Old Testament, the Dead Sea Scrolls — discovered in 1947 and dating from before the time of Jesus — included a complete scroll of Isaiah roughly a thousand years older than the manuscripts we had before. When scholars compared it to the medieval text, the agreement was extraordinary; across a thousand years of copying, the message stood unchanged. That is not what a corrupted text looks like; it is what a carefully guarded one looks like.

For the New Testament, we possess thousands of Greek manuscripts plus early translations and quotations — including fragments of the Gospels from the second and third centuries, well before Islam. This abundance is precisely what lets scholars see the small copying differences (a spelling, a word order) and reconstruct the original with confidence. A text known from a single late copy could hide its errors; a text known from thousands of early ones

cannot. The variants are visible *because* the evidence is overwhelming, and none of them touch the gospel.

"Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will not pass away." — Matthew 24:35 (WEB)

So the honest picture is the opposite of the rumor. There is no trace of an earlier, "purer," prophet-only Bible that was later overwritten to insert the deity of Christ; the crucified and risen Lord is in the *earliest* layer we can reach, on every continent the church reached, copied by communities that could not have coordinated. To examine the manuscripts is not to find a corrupted book, but a remarkably stable one — which simply returns us to the harder and more important question: not whether the Bible was changed, but whether what it has always said is *true*.

What corrupting the Bible would actually have required

Step back and consider what the corruption theory is really asking us to believe, because the logistics expose how unlikely it is. By the time anyone might have wished to alter the Christian Scriptures, they were already *everywhere* — copied by hand in Greek, Latin, Syriac, Coptic, Armenian, and more; scattered across Egypt, Asia Minor, Greece, Italy, Africa, and the East; read in thousands of independent congregations; quoted endlessly in the letters and sermons of early teachers. There was no central headquarters, no single library, no controlling authority that *could* have recalled every copy and edited them in unison.

To corrupt such a text — to insert, say, the deity and resurrection of Christ where it had not been — someone would have had to track down every manuscript on three continents, in a half-dozen languages, held by communities that often disagreed with one another, and change them all identically, leaving no older "uncorrupted" copy and no record of protest anywhere. That is not how the historical record looks, and frankly it is not how textual transmission *can* work. When documents are copied widely and independently, errors creep in *locally* and are easily spotted by comparison; coordinated, universal, undetectable alteration is impossible.

"The grass withers, and its flower falls; but the Lord's word endures forever." — 1 Peter 1:24-25 (WEB)

So the corruption theory, examined practically, asks for a conspiracy no one had the power to carry out and which left no fingerprints. The simpler and better-evidenced explanation is the one the manuscripts themselves give: the text we hold is, in all that matters, the text the apostles wrote. Which means the real question was never the manuscripts. It is the message.



Chapter Four — Does the Old Testament Predict Muhammad?

The objection, stated fairly

Muslims are taught that the coming of Muhammad was foretold in the earlier scriptures, and several Bible passages are commonly cited: the promise of a "prophet like Moses" (Deuteronomy 18:18), the "servant" of Isaiah 42, and Jesus' promise of a coming "Comforter" or "Helper" (the *Paraclete*) in John 14–16, which some read as a prophecy of *Ahmad* / Muhammad. If these texts point to Muhammad, then the Bible itself endorses Islam. It is a powerful argument — if the texts say what is claimed. So let us read each one in context.

"A prophet like Moses" (Deuteronomy 18:18)

*"I will raise up a prophet from among their brothers, like you. I will put my words in his mouth, and he shall speak to them all that I shall command him." —
Deuteronomy 18:18 (WEB)*

The argument runs: Muhammad, like Moses, was a lawgiver, a military leader, and a married man — more "like Moses" than Jesus was. But read the qualifier: "from among **their brothers**." In the immediate context, "their brothers" means from among the Israelites themselves — and the very next line in Deuteronomy 18 says God will raise this prophet "from among **you**, of your brothers," addressed to Israel. The New Testament identifies this prophet as Jesus, an Israelite of the tribe of Judah (Acts 3:22). Muhammad was an Arab, not an Israelite. Moreover, the test of a true prophet given in the *same passage* is that his words must come true and must not turn people to other gods (Deuteronomy 18:20-22; 13:1-5). The "prophet like Moses" was to be one of Israel's own. That points to Jesus, not to a prophet from outside the covenant people.

Isaiah 42 and the Servant

Isaiah 42 opens, "Behold, my servant, whom I uphold; my chosen, in whom my soul delights" (Isaiah 42:1). The chapter is sometimes applied to Muhammad. But read it whole. This servant "will not cry, nor lift up his voice, nor cause it to be heard in the street. He won't break a bruised reed. He won't quench a dimly burning wick" (Isaiah 42:2-3) — a gentle, non-violent figure. He is a "covenant for the people, as a light for the nations, to open the blind eyes, to bring the prisoners out of the dungeon" (42:6-7). And crucially, Matthew's Gospel explicitly

identifies this servant as Jesus, quoting Isaiah 42 of Him directly (Matthew 12:17-21). The servant of Isaiah is part of a series of "Servant Songs" that climax in Isaiah 53 — the servant "pierced for our transgressions." Read in context, Isaiah 42 describes a gentle, suffering, light-bringing servant who dies for sins, which is how the New Testament reads it.

The Comforter (John 14–16)

This is the strongest of the three claims, so it deserves the closest reading. Jesus promises: "I will pray to the Father, and he will give you another Counselor, that he may be with you forever: the Spirit of truth" (John 14:16-17). Some Muslims read "another Counselor" (Greek *paraklētos*) as a prophecy of *Ahmad* / Muhammad, suggesting the word was originally *periklytos* ("praised one," echoing the meaning of "Ahmad").

But Jesus tells us, in the same breath, exactly who the Comforter is and what He does — and none of it fits a human prophet who would come six centuries later:

- He is **"the Spirit of truth"** and **"the Holy Spirit"** (John 14:17, 26) — explicitly a Spirit, not a man.
- He would come **"in a few days"**, not in six hundred years — "you will be baptized in the Holy Spirit not many days from now" (Acts 1:5), fulfilled at Pentecost ten days after Jesus ascended.
- He would **dwelt in the disciples** — "he lives with you, and will be in you" (John 14:17). A human prophet in Arabia could not live inside first-century disciples.
- He would **not speak about Himself** but glorify Jesus — "He will glorify me, for he will take from what is mine, and will declare it to you" (John 16:14).

Read in context, the Comforter is unmistakably the Holy Spirit, given to Jesus' followers at Pentecost — and the Bible says He arrived, on schedule, within days, exactly as Jesus said. The reading that makes Him a future human prophet has to ignore every descriptive detail Jesus gave in the same conversation.

The pattern in these arguments

Notice what each of these three arguments has in common: each is persuasive *only* when the verse is lifted out of its paragraph. Put the verse back — "from among their brothers," the gentle servant Matthew names as Jesus, the Spirit who comes in days and lives inside the disciples — and the case evaporates. This is exactly why the rule of this book matters. Read it in context, and the Old and New Testaments point not away from Jesus but straight to Him.

The test a true prophet must pass

The question of later prophets is not one the Bible leaves us to guess about; it gives explicit *tests*, and applying them honestly is part of reading in context. The Torah lays down two criteria a true prophet must meet. First, his words must come true:

"When a prophet speaks in Yahweh's name, if the thing doesn't follow, nor happen, that is the thing which Yahweh has not spoken. The prophet has spoken it presumptuously." — Deuteronomy 18:21-22 (WEB)

Second — and this one is decisive — even a prophet whose signs come true must be rejected if he turns people *away from the God who has already revealed Himself* to follow other gods or another way (Deuteronomy 13:1-5). The test is not merely "Did he perform wonders?" but "Does his message agree with what God has already spoken?" A later voice that contradicts the earlier revelation cannot be from the same God, for "God is not a man, that he should lie" (Numbers 23:19), and He does not reverse Himself.

This is why, for the Christian, the question of any later prophet comes down to a single point: does his message agree with the Christ already revealed in the Scriptures — the crucified, risen Son of God — or does it deny Him? The New Testament applies exactly this test: "every spirit who confesses that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh is of God, and every spirit who doesn't confess that Jesus has come in the flesh is not of God" (1 John 4:2-3). We do not reject later claims out of prejudice, but by the measure God Himself gave: a true word from God will never overturn the Son God has already sent. So the road leads us, unavoidably, back to the central question — who is Jesus?

Reading prophecy forward, not a name backward

It is worth naming the *method* difference underneath the prophecy question, because it explains why Christians and Muslims read these texts so differently. The Christian way of reading fulfilled prophecy is to look for a *pattern and a person* that the text genuinely anticipates, confirmed by the New Testament's own use — not to hunt for a *name* hidden in the letters. When the Gospels say Jesus fulfilled the Scriptures, they point to things like Bethlehem as the Messiah's birthplace:

"But you, Bethlehem Ephrathah, being small among the clans of Judah, out of you one will come out to me that is to be ruler in Israel; whose goings out are from of old, from ancient times." — Micah 5:2 (WEB)

A specific town, named seven centuries early, where a ruler "from ancient times" would be born — and Jesus was born there. That is prophecy read forward: a detail planted in advance and matched by an event. It is a very different thing from taking a verse that, in context, speaks of Israel or the Holy Spirit and reading a later figure's name into it. The first respects what the text meant to its original hearers; the second imposes a meaning from outside.

This is the heart of "read it in context." Jesus told His disciples that "all things which are written in the law of Moses, the prophets, and the psalms concerning me must be fulfilled" (Luke 24:44) — and then showed them, passage by passage, a coherent portrait the texts had been painting all along: born of a virgin, in Bethlehem, of David's line, pierced, buried with the rich, raised the third day. The case for Jesus is not one clever proof-text but a cumulative portrait, drawn across centuries, that He alone fits. That is the kind of fulfillment worth examining — and the kind the texts, read in context, actually offer.

Chapter Five — Who Is Jesus: Prophet or More?

Where the two faiths truly part

We have cleared away the objections about the Trinity, the text, and the prophecies. Now we reach the real fork in the road, the question on which Christianity and Islam finally divide: **who is Jesus?**

Islam honors Jesus (Isa) highly — as a mighty prophet, the Messiah, born of the virgin Mary, a worker of miracles, sinless, who will return. That is a higher view of Jesus than many secular people hold, and a Christian should gladly acknowledge it. But Islam stops there: Jesus is a prophet and only a prophet; He is not divine, He is not the Son of God in any literal sense, and — most sharply — He was not crucified.

The Christian claim is that "prophet" is true but not enough. Jesus is the prophet *and* far more: the eternal Son of God, who was crucified for the sins of the world and rose again. The two faiths cannot both be right here, and the difference is not small — it is everything.

Did Jesus claim to be more than a prophet?

Muslims often say, "Jesus never said 'I am God, worship me.'" It is a fair challenge, and the answer is more interesting than a single missing sentence. Jesus revealed His identity the way the prophets did — not with a modern slogan, but by speaking and acting as only God may.

He took the personal self-identification of the God of Israel — "I am he," the phrase by which Yahweh says "there is no god beside me" (Deuteronomy 32:39; Isaiah 43:10) — and applied it to Himself: "Before Abraham came into existence, I AM" (John 8:58). His hearers understood Him so exactly that they picked up stones to execute Him for blasphemy (John 8:59). He forgave sins, and His critics rightly objected, "Who can forgive sins but God alone?" (Mark 2:7). He received worship and did not refuse it — when Thomas saw the risen Jesus and said, "My Lord and my God!" Jesus accepted it and blessed those who would believe likewise (John 20:28-29). A true prophet who was *only* a prophet would have torn his clothes and refused such worship, as Paul and Barnabas did when men tried to worship them (Acts 14:14-15), and as the angel did in Revelation (Revelation 22:8-9). Jesus did the opposite. (Our companion book *I Am He* follows this single thread in detail.)

Was Jesus crucified?

Here is the second great divide. The Qur'an is understood by most Muslims to deny the crucifixion — that the Jews "didn't kill him, nor did they crucify him, but it appeared so to them" (Surah 4:157), often explained as God rescuing Jesus and substituting another in his place. Christianity stands or falls on the opposite claim: that Jesus really died on a cross and really rose.

This, again, is a question history can weigh. The crucifixion of Jesus is one of the best-attested events of the ancient world — affirmed not only by all four Gospels and the letters of Paul (written within decades, some within a few years), but by non-Christian sources of the era, including Roman and Jewish writers who had no interest in promoting the church. The earliest Christian creed, which Paul says he "received" and passed on within a few years of the events, states it plainly: "Christ died for our sins according to the Scriptures, that he was buried, that he was raised on the third day" (1 Corinthians 15:3-4). Crucially, the Hebrew Scriptures had *predicted* a pierced and suffering servant centuries earlier — "he was pierced for our transgressions" (Isaiah 53:5), "they have pierced my hands and feet" (Psalm 22:16). The cross was not an accident or an appearance; it was the appointment the whole Old Testament had been pointing toward.

For the Christian, the crucifixion is not a defeat to be explained away but the very center of God's love: "God commends his own love toward us, in that while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us" (Romans 5:8). To deny the cross is, from the Christian side, to remove the heart of the gospel — for if Jesus did not die, then the price of sin was never paid. (Our companion book *The Highest Price and the Greatest Love* unfolds this.)

Why this difference is worth everything

If Islam is right, Jesus is a revered prophet and we should honor him as such. If Christianity is right, Jesus is God-with-us who died to save you, and to treat Him as merely a prophet is to miss the rescue God Himself came to bring. Both cannot be true. This is not a difference to paper over with talk of "we all believe the same things." We do not — not here. And because the stakes are eternal, the question deserves your most honest attention: not "which faith is my tradition?" but "who is Jesus, really?"

The titles the Qur'an gives Jesus — and the questions they raise

Here is common ground that turns, gently, into the deepest question. The Qur'an itself honors Jesus with titles it gives to no other prophet. It affirms His virgin birth. It calls Him *al-Masih*, the Messiah. And remarkably, it calls Him a "Word" from God and a "Spirit" from Him. A fair-minded Muslim reader should feel the weight of these honors: no other prophet in Islam is born of a virgin, named the Messiah, or called God's Word and Spirit.

These titles raise questions they do not, within Islam, fully answer. *Why* is this prophet, and no other, born without a human father? *Why* is He, and no other, called the Messiah — the anointed King the Hebrew Scriptures had promised? And what does it mean to call Him the "Word" of God? For the Christian, the Hebrew and Christian Scriptures answer precisely these questions: the Word of God is eternal and divine — "the Word was with God, and the Word was God" (John 1:1) — and became flesh in the virgin-born Messiah. The very honors Islam pays Jesus point, when followed in context, toward the fuller identity the Gospels proclaim.

We do not press this to score a point, but because the titles invite the question. When Thomas, a Jewish monotheist who would never call a mere man "God," met the risen Jesus, he fell down and said:

"Thomas answered him, 'My Lord and my God!'" — John 20:28 (WEB)

And Jesus did not correct him. The titles "Messiah," "Word," and "Spirit" are not small. Read in their full context, they ask the Muslim reader to consider that Jesus is more than even a mighty prophet — that He is who Thomas, seeing Him alive, confessed Him to be.

Why a crucified Messiah was the plan, not the failure

The hardest thing for a Muslim to accept is often not that Jesus existed or taught, but that He was *crucified* — for surely God would not abandon His Messiah to such a shameful death? The Qur'an, as most read it, denies the crucifixion partly out of this honorable instinct: God protects His prophets. So let me answer the instinct, not just the claim.

The Christian does not see the cross as God *failing* to rescue His prophet. We see it as the very thing God had planned and foretold — the Messiah's mission, not His defeat. Isaiah said so seven centuries before it happened, and said it was *God's own will*:

"Yet it pleased Yahweh to bruise him. He has caused him to suffer... when you make his soul an offering for sin, he will see his offspring." — Isaiah 53:10 (WEB)

The suffering was not an accident God failed to prevent; it "pleased Yahweh" — it was the offering for sin the whole sacrificial system had pointed toward. Paul admits frankly that a

crucified Messiah is a scandal to the religious mind — "we preach Christ crucified, a stumbling block to Jews and foolishness to Greeks" (1 Corinthians 1:23) — and then insists it is precisely there that "the power of God and the wisdom of God" are revealed. The cross looks like the prophet's humiliation; it is in fact the King's coronation, the Lamb's sacrifice, the moment our debt was paid. To remove the cross to protect Jesus' honor is, from the Christian side, to remove the very act in which His honor and our salvation shine brightest. The empty tomb is God's vindication — not that the cross was avoided, but that it was conquered.

Chapter Six — Heaven, Hell, and How a Person Is Saved

A shared seriousness about eternity

Christianity and Islam both take eternity with deadly seriousness. Both teach a real judgment, a real paradise, and a real hell. Even the words overlap: the New Testament's word for hell, **Gehenna** — drawn from the Valley of Hinnom outside Jerusalem, where child sacrifice once defiled the land — stands behind the Arabic **Jahannam**. The concepts are cousins: a place of final judgment for those who reject God. Here, at least, we are not far apart in our sense that the choices of this life echo forever.

But underneath the shared vocabulary lies the deepest practical difference between the two faiths — a difference not about whether judgment is real, but about *how anyone could possibly pass it*.

Two answers to one question

Ask a thoughtful person of either faith, "How can a sinner stand before a holy God?" and you will hear two very different answers.

The Islamic answer, broadly, is one of **submission and the scale**: live in submission to God, perform the duties He commands, do more good than evil, and hope in His mercy. Salvation is something you work toward, with the outcome finally in God's hands, and assurance is, for most, not promised in this life.

The Christian answer is starkly different: **you cannot tip the scale, and you do not have to**. The Bible's diagnosis is severe — "all have sinned, and fall short of the glory of God" (Romans 3:23) — and its remedy is not a heavier weight of good works but a substitute who bears the debt. "By grace you have been saved through faith, and that not of yourselves; it is the gift of God, not of works, that no one would boast" (Ephesians 2:8-9). Salvation is not earned; it is received, as a free gift, by trusting what Christ has done.

The scandal and the comfort of grace

To a mind trained on the scale, grace can sound too easy, even unjust — *does God just overlook sin?* No. This is the genius of the cross: God does not ignore the debt; He pays it Himself, in His Son, so that He is both "just, and the justifier of him who has faith in Jesus"

(Romans 3:26). Justice is satisfied *and* the sinner is forgiven, because the price was paid by Another. Sin is not waved away; it is carried.

And this is where the gospel offers something Islam, by its own structure, does not: **assurance**. Because salvation rests on what Christ has finished rather than on what I might yet accomplish, a Christian can know — now, today — that they are accepted. "These things I have written to you who believe in the name of the Son of God, that you may know that you have eternal life" (1 John 5:13). Not *hope so*. *Know*. That is not arrogance; it is confidence in the sufficiency of the cross rather than in oneself.

What each faith finally offers

So the offer on the table is genuinely different. Islam offers a path of submission with the verdict deferred to the Day of Judgment. The gospel offers a finished rescue and a verdict you can know now, not because you are good but because Christ is, and He has taken your place. If that is true, it is the best news a human being could hear — and it is freely offered to you, with nothing to pay, because the price has already been paid.

The gift of assurance

There is one more difference here so practical that it touches every night's sleep, and it is worth naming with care. In most understandings of Islam, a person lives in submission and hopes in God's mercy, but cannot *know* in this life how the scale will finally tip; the verdict waits for the Day of Judgment. The gospel offers something its structure makes possible only because salvation rests on Christ's finished work rather than on the believer's performance — it offers *assurance now*:

"These things I have written to you who believe in the name of the Son of God, that you may know that you have eternal life." — 1 John 5:13 (WEB)

Not "hope so." *Know*. This is not arrogance — as if the Christian were claiming to be good enough. It is the opposite: the Christian's confidence rests entirely *outside himself*, on what Christ has already accomplished. "By grace you have been saved through faith, and that not of yourselves; it is the gift of God, not of works" (Ephesians 2:8-9). Because the debt is paid by Another, and paid in full, the verdict is already in.

I offer this not as a debating point but as something precious that a Muslim friend may never have been told is available: that one can stand before a holy God not anxiously hoping the good has outweighed the bad, but resting in a finished work and a settled welcome. If salvation depends on the scale of our deeds, no honest person can ever be sure. If it depends

on the cross of Christ, received by faith, then assurance is not presumption — it is simply trusting the sufficiency of what He has done. That is a rest worth examining, whatever you conclude.

The scale and the running Father

Behind the two ways of salvation lie two different pictures of God Himself, and it is worth seeing them side by side. In the religion of the scale, God is supremely the Judge, weighing each deed, and the worshiper approaches with hope but never certainty. Jesus offered a second picture — not to deny that God is Judge, but to reveal His heart toward returning sinners. He told of a son who squandered everything and came home in disgrace, rehearsing a speech to earn a servant's place. But before he could finish, the father did something no dignified Middle Eastern patriarch would do:

"But while he was still far off, his father saw him, and was moved with compassion, and ran, and fell on his neck, and kissed him." — Luke 15:20 (WEB)

The father *ran*. He did not wait at the door with folded arms for the son to prove himself; he ran to meet him, embraced him before the apology was out, and called for a robe, a ring, and a feast. This is the God Jesus reveals — not a reluctant judge slowly persuaded by our good deeds, but a Father scanning the horizon, ready to run. The difference between the scale and the running Father is not that one takes sin seriously and the other does not; the cross shows that God takes sin with deadly seriousness. The difference is *who pays*. On the scale, you do. With the Father, He has — and the son's part is simply to come home. I commend this picture to you not to dismiss your reverence for God's justice, which Christians share, but to ask whether the God who runs might be even greater than the God who only weighs.

Chapter Seven — Reading It Together: An Invitation

What we have done, and not done

We have walked through the hardest questions: the Trinity and tawhid, the charge of corruption, the alleged prophecies of Muhammad, the identity of Jesus, the cross, and the way of salvation. In each case the method has been the same — *read it in context* — and in each case the contested verse, read whole, points back to the Jesus the Christians proclaim: the eternal Son, crucified and risen, the one Savior.

I have not "won" anything. Arguments do not save anyone, and I would not want them to. What I hope I have done is clear away the misunderstandings that keep the real question buried — so that you can face it without the noise. The real question was never "is the Bible corrupted?" or "is the Trinity three gods?" Those, read in context, answer themselves. The real question is the one Jesus put to His own disciples: "Who do you say that I am?" (Matthew 16:15).

An invitation, not a demand

The Qur'an itself says, "There is no compulsion in religion" — and on this, Scripture agrees: faith that is forced is not faith at all. So this book ends not with a demand but with an open door. I am not asking you to abandon your love for God, your reverence for the prophets, or your hatred of idolatry — keep all of it. I am asking you to do one thing: read the accounts of Jesus for yourself, in context, and ask God honestly to show you who He is.

*"You will seek me, and find me, when you search for me with all your heart." —
Jeremiah 29:13 (WEB)*

Read the Gospel of John slowly. Watch what Jesus says and does. Ask the God you already believe in to make the truth plain. If Jesus is only a prophet, you will lose nothing by looking closely. But if He is who He claimed to be — God come near, the Lamb who takes away the sin of the world — then to find Him is to find everything.

The hope I am holding out

The whole of the Bible bends toward one promise: "the earth will be filled with the knowledge of the glory of Yahweh, as the waters cover the sea" (Habakkuk 2:14). Not the triumph of one

tribe over another, but the knowledge of God's glory filling the whole earth — including you, wherever you are reading this. And that glory, the Bible says, has a face: "He who has seen me has seen the Father" (John 14:9).

You have read a Christian's honest answer. I have tried to give it with humility and respect, as my own Scriptures require. Now I can only do what every honest writer must finally do — step back, and leave you with the One the whole book has been about, who still says, to Muslim and Christian and skeptic alike:

"Come to me, all you who labor and are heavily burdened, and I will give you rest."
— *Matthew 11:28 (WEB)*

Read it in context. Then come and see.

A prayer the honest seeker can pray

If you have read this far, you have given Christianity a fair hearing — and the only honest next step is not to take my word for it, but to ask God Himself. Jesus made a remarkable promise to anyone willing to *do* God's will, not merely debate it:

"If anyone desires to do his will, he will know about the teaching, whether it is from God, or if I am speaking from myself." — John 7:17 (WEB)

The promise is that sincerity will be answered — that the one who genuinely wants the truth, and is willing to follow it wherever it leads, will be given light. So I leave you not with a demand but with an invitation you can act on tonight, in your own room, in your own words. Pray something like this, honestly:

"God, you know I want the truth more than I want to be right. If Jesus is only a prophet, keep me from error. But if He is who the Gospels say — your Word, the Lamb, the risen Lord — then show me, and give me the courage to follow. Open my eyes as I read."

Then open the Gospel of John and read it slowly, a chapter at a time, asking that question as you go. You risk nothing by looking closely; if Jesus is merely a prophet, an honest reading will cost you nothing. But if He is more — if the One the whole Bible was pointing to has come, drunk our cup, and risen — then to find Him is to find everything. The God who promised, "You will seek me, and find me, when you search for me with all your heart" (Jeremiah 29:13), does not break His promises. Seek Him, and see.

Appendix — The Questions and Where They Land

A quick reference to the contested points and the answer in one line each (read the chapters for the full case).

Question	The short answer (read in context)
Do Christians worship three gods?	No — one God, eternally Father, Son, and Spirit. "Yahweh is one" (Deut 6:4).
Is the Trinity <i>shirk</i> (associating a partner)?	No — the Son is not a creature beside God but the eternal Word who "was God" (John 1:1).
Has the Bible been corrupted (<i>tahrif</i>)?	No textual evidence; the manuscript record shows a stable text, with the high view of Christ in the earliest layer.
Does Deuteronomy 18:18 predict Muhammad?	No — the prophet is "from among their brothers," an Israelite; the NT names Jesus (Acts 3:22).
Does Isaiah 42 predict Muhammad?	No — Matthew applies the gentle, light-bringing servant to Jesus (Matthew 12:17-21).
Is the Comforter (John 14–16) Muhammad?	No — Jesus calls Him "the Holy Spirit," coming "in a few days," dwelling <i>in</i> the disciples (Acts 1:5; 2).
Did Jesus claim to be more than a prophet?	Yes — "Before Abraham was, I AM" (John 8:58); He forgave sins and received worship (Mark 2:7; John 20:28).
Was Jesus crucified?	Yes — affirmed by the earliest sources and creeds, foretold in Isaiah 53 and Psalm 22.
How is a person saved?	Not by the scale of works but by grace through faith in Christ, who paid the debt (Ephesians 2:8-9).

About this book

Read It in Context is published freely by **Hope of Glory Ministry**, that the earth may be filled with the knowledge of the glory of the Lord. It may be read, shared, and given away without charge. All Scripture is from the World English Bible (public domain). We hold the historic Nicene faith and the plain reading of Scripture; we compare beliefs and never demean persons, the Prophet of Islam, or the Qur'an.

To ask any question — honestly, and without pressure — visit Hope of Glory Ministry: Ask Hope, or read the Gospel of John for yourself. The gospel is free, and there is no compulsion in it.

"Christ in you, the hope of glory." — Colossians 1:27 (WEB)